consumption is vision impairment, especially night blindness. The low intake of fruits, vegetables and milk and dairy products by adolescents contributes to their less than optimal intake of vitamin A.

Vitamin E is well known for its antioxidant properties, which become increasingly important as body mass expands during adolescence. Fortified breakfast cereals and nuts are good sources of vitamin E. Vitamin C is involved in the synthesis of collagen and other connective tissues

Fibre

Dietary fibre is important for normal bowel function, and plays a role in the prevention of chronic diseases, such as certain cancers, coronary artery disease, and type 2 diabetes mellitus and reduces the risk of obesity. Increased intake of fruit, vegetables, and whole grains increases the fibre intake. Adolescents who skip breakfast or do not routinely consume whole grain cereals are at high risk for having an inadequate consumption of fibre.

Dietary Guidelines for Adolescents

Diet in adolescents is very significant because it influences the nutritional status later in life.

- Adequate well balanced nutritious food should be taken to prevent obesity or under nutrition.
- An adolescent girl should take enough calcium rich foods in her diet to increase bone density and delay the onset of osteoporosis.
- Should not miss breakfast.
- Junk food should be avoided.
- Avoid empty calorie foods such as carbonated beverages.
- Iron rich foods may be included in the diet to prevent anaemia.
- Calorie and protein rich foods should be taken to support the growth spurt.
- Include fruits and vegetables in the diet to meet the vitamin, mineral and fibre requirement.

Table 11 Balanced Diet for Adolescents (Number of portions)

		10-12 Years		13-15 Years		16-18 Years	
Food groups	**g/Portion**	**Girls**	**Boys**	**Girls**	**Boys**	**Girls**	**Boys**
Cereals & millets	30	8	10	11	14	11	15
Pulses	30	2	2	2	2.5	2.5	3
Milk & its products	100	5	5	5	5	5	5
Roots & tubers	100	1	1	1	1.5	2	2
Green leafy veg.	100	1	1	1	1	1	1
Other vegetables	100	2	2	2	2	2	2
Fruits	100	1	1	1	1	1	1
Sugar	5	6	6	5	4	5	6
Fat/oil (visible)	5	7	7	8	9	7	10

Source: Dietary Guidelines for Indians, National Institute of Nutrition, Hyderabad, 2011.

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